Common Mistakes in IELTS Writing Task 1

1. Not Writing an Overview ❌

This is one of the biggest mistakes.
Many students only describe details and forget the overview paragraph.

☑ Always write a clear overview after the introduction.

Bad Example:
The graph shows sales from 2010 to 2020.

Better:
Overall, sales increased significantly over the period, despite some fluctuations.

2. Giving Personal Opinions ❌

Task 1 is NOT an opinion essay.

Do not write:

. "I think…"
. "In my opinion…"
. "I believe…"

Bad Example:
“I think the company performed very well.”
Better:
“The company’s sales increased considerably.”

3. Copying the Question Directly ❌

- Many students copy the task question word-for-word.

This lowers the vocabulary score.
Bad Example:
The graph below shows the percentage of students.
Better:
“The line graph illustrates the proportion of students…”

4. Using Informal Language ❌

Avoid informal words.
Bad:

- got up
- went crazy
- huge jump

Better:

- increased
- rose sharply
- experienced a significant rise

5. Describing Every Single Detail ❌

Students often write every number from the graph.

This wastes time and reduces clarity.

☑ ***Focus on:***

- overall trends
- highest point
- lowest point
- major changes
- comparisons

6. Wrong Use of Tense ❌

Tense mistakes are very common.

✓ **Past Data → Past Tense**

✓ **Future Prediction → Future Tense**

Bad Example:

Sales increase in 2010.

Better:
Sales increased in 2010.

7. Using Repetitive Vocabulary ❌

Many students repeat:

- increase
- decrease
- big
- small

again and again.

☑ **Use synonyms:**

- rise
- climb
- surge
- decline
- drop
- plunge

8. Grammar Mistakes with Numbers ❌

Bad:
The number of students are.
Better:
The number of students **is.**

9. No Clear Paragraphing ❌

Some students write everything in one paragraph.

☑ **Recommended Structure:**

1. Introduction
2. Overview
3. Body Paragraph 1
4. Body Paragraph 2

10. Writing Too Few Words ❌

Task 1 requires:

*****at least 150 words.*****

Writing less may reduce your score.

11. Wrong Comparison ❌

Students sometimes compare unrelated data.

Bad:

Cars were higher than 2010.

Better:

Car sales in 2020 were higher than in 2010.

12. Overusing Complex Vocabulary ❌

Using difficult words incorrectly is dangerous.

☑ Simple and accurate English is better than unnatural advanced vocabulary.

13. Ignoring Units ❌

Students often forget:

- %
- dollars
- kilograms
- millions

Bad:

Sales reached 50.

Better:

Sales reached 50 million dollars.

14. No Data Support ❌

Always support trends with figures.

Bad:

Sales increased significantly.

Better:

Sales increased significantly from 20% to 65%.

15. Confusing “Amount” and “Number”

Use “number” for countable nouns:

- students
- cars
- people

Use “amount” for uncountable nouns:

- water
- money
- pollution

Final Advice:

To achieve a good band score in IELTS Writing Task 1:

- ☑ write a clear overview
- ☑ use correct tense
- ☑ make comparisons
- ☑ avoid repetition
- ☑ use academic vocabulary naturally
- ☑ focus on major trends, not every detail

Most importantly:

clarity is more important than difficult English.